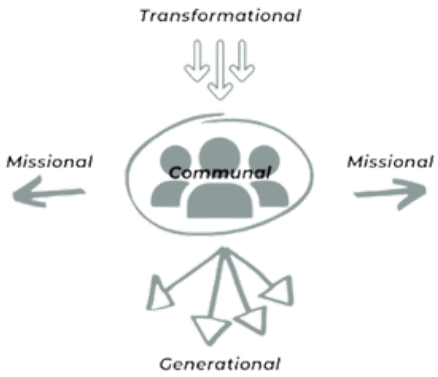
Empower



DISCIPLEMAKING COMMUNITIES

Western cultures can often view the Bible through an individualistic lens, whereas other cultures gravitate towards a communal lens. In English, there is no good word that expresses the plural form of "you." Yet, "all of you" is often a more accurate reading of many of Paul's instructions to the early churches in the Epistles.

READ

Spend time reading 1 Thessalonians 1:2-10 in the "you'all" version. As you read, consider the question: What separates a group of friends from an intentional, disciplemaking community?

"2We thank God always for all y'all, mentioning y'all in our prayers, 3constantly remembering before our God and Father y'all's work of faith, labor of love, and perseverance of hope in our Lord Jesus Christ. 4We know, siblings beloved by God, that y'all are chosen, 5and that our gospel came to y'all not in word only, but also in power, and in the Holy Spirit, and with deep conviction. Y'all saw how we lived among y'all for your* sake. 6Y'all became imitators of us and of the Lord, having received the word with the joy of the Holy Spirit despite deep oppression.

7As a result y'all became an example to all the believers in Macedonia and in Achaia. 8For the word of the Lord has reverberated out from y'all, not only in Macedonia and Achaia, but y'all's faith in God has spread everywhere. We don't even need to say anything, 9for the people themselves are reporting what kind of reception we had with y'all, and how y'all turned to God from idols to serve a living and true God, 10and to wait for His Son from heaven, whom he raised from the dead: Jesus, who delivers us from the wrath to come."

OBSERVE

Disciplemaking Communities (DMCs) can manifest themselves in a variety of contexts, but all share four primary categories (below). Consider the questions below as you think back through 1 Thess 1:2-10.

- Communal: Are they friends? How are the 'One Another's' of Scripture being lived out?
- Transformational: Is the Gospel transforming lives of individuals? Are there ways community could help spur this transformation on?
- Missional: Are friends being reached with the Gospel? Do individuals in the DMC know where their areas of influence exist? Are there shared areas of influence among those in the DMC that can be reached together?
- Generational: Is there the intention of reaching the next generation? How is the next generation included in this DMC? How will this DMC be used to launch teams to help future generations?

PERSONALIZE & APPLY

Are there communities you are currently a part of (insider) that could become Disciplemaking Communities? What are some specific next steps you could take?

Are there situations where you function as either someone who comes alongside another to help them minister, or an area in your life where you are directly ministering among others? How might these areas benefit from what you've observed about DMCs? What is one step you could take to help this area function as an intentional disciplemaking community?

This journal was made by the University of Arizona Navigators staff in 2020, with the latest update in 2025, and is meant to be shared. Please do not reproduce for profit.

For reproduction, corrections, suggestions for improvement, or to request a digital copy please email Ryan Mullarkey at ryan.mullarkey@navigators.org